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By our spontaneous and good will, we have given and conceded ... to all our kingdom, these below written liberties.

Henry III

1225 reissue of Magna Carta

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to the Provisions of Oxford in 1258. These placed the government in the hands of a committee of 15 barons and a parliament (made up largely of nobles) summoned three times a year. The system soon collapsed, but a revolt in 1264 led by Simon de Montfort (the Second Barons' War), led to the calling in 1265 of the first parliament to include representatives not just of the wealthy elite, but of all the people. It included two burgesses (representatives) from each large town and two knights from each shire.

By the 14th century, this body was exerting its rights under Chapter 12 of Magna Carta, interpreting it to mean that the king could not raise any tax without first seeking Parliament's consent. The charter's influence waned during the 15th century, as the Tudor monarchy strengthened. In the 17th century, however, it became a highly

King John's assent to Magna Carta was marked in 1957 by this memorial at Runnymede on land leased by the American Bar Association (ABA). Its president William Hubbard declared the charter “an enduring worldwide symbol of liberty and the rule of law.”

effective shield for parliamentary rights against the power of the Stuart kings during the English Civil Wars that resulted in the execution of Charles I, the exile of Charles II, and Cromwell's rule.

A broad, lasting influence

In the late 18th century, Magna Carta's defense against royal tyranny resonated with the American colonists' struggle for independence from British rule. The wording of the US Constitution in 1789 and the later Bill of Rights was influenced by the limitations on the arbitrary power of a ruler that Magna Carta had established more than 500 years earlier.

In Britain, by the 19th century, much of Magna Carta had become obsolete. From 1828 onward, most of its provisions were removed from the statute book. Only four of its chapters are still in force today: the first, on the liberties of the English Church; Chapter 13 on the privileges

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The democratic aspiration is no mere recent phase in human history. It was written in Magna Carta.

Franklin D. Roosevelt

32nd US president (1933–1945)

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of the City of London; and Chapters 39 and 40 on the right to trial according to the law and the forbidding of arbitrary seizures by the Crown. For these two chapters, Magna Carta is still perceived as the cornerstone of British legal rights and a turning point in constitutional government and human rights. ■

